



Get edumacated!

“Homeric infixation is a morphological construction that has recently gained currency in Vernacular American English. People who are familiar with this construction invariably credit the TV animation series, *The Simpsons*, particularly the speech of the main character Homer Simpson, for popularizing this construction.”

(Yu, A. C. L. 2004. Reduplication in English Homeric infixation. *NELS* 34)

Many speakers of American English, particularly younger speakers, can insert the syllable “*ma*” into a word to produce a humorous variant like “edumacation” or “saxomaphone”. For many words, everyone agrees on how the “edumacated” variant should be formed, but there’s some disagreement, too.

Below, three people give what they feel are the correct “edumacated” versions of twelve words. We’ve underlined the stressed vowels of all the words; you should likewise indicate stress with underlining in your answers.

	Alan	Barbara	Chris
Alab <u>a</u> ma	<u>A</u> lamab <u>a</u> ma	<u>A</u> lamab <u>a</u> ma	<u>A</u> lamab <u>a</u> ma
cap <u>i</u> tal	<u>c</u> apim <u>a</u> ta <u>l</u>	<u>c</u> apim <u>a</u> ta <u>l</u>	<u>c</u> apim <u>a</u> ta <u>l</u>
cap <u>a</u> tain	<u>c</u> apam <u>a</u> ta <u>i</u> n	<u>c</u> aptam <u>a</u> ta <u>i</u> n	uh... i'm not sure
congrat <u>a</u> lations	<u>c</u> ongrat <u>a</u> mal <u>a</u> tions	<u>c</u> ongrat <u>a</u> mal <u>a</u> tions	<u>c</u> ongrat <u>a</u> mal <u>a</u> tions
hypoth <u>e</u> r <u>m</u> ia	<u>h</u> ypom <u>a</u> th <u>e</u> r <u>m</u> ia	<u>h</u> ypom <u>a</u> th <u>e</u> r <u>m</u> ia	<u>h</u> ypom <u>a</u> th <u>e</u> r <u>m</u> ia
ob <u>o</u> oe	<u>o</u> bam <u>a</u> bo <u>e</u>	<u>o</u> boem <u>a</u> bo <u>e</u>	<u>o</u> oom <u>a</u> bo <u>e</u>
oct <u>a</u> gon	<u>o</u> ctam <u>a</u> gon	<u>o</u> ctam <u>a</u> gon	<u>o</u> ctam <u>a</u> gon
oct <u>e</u> t			i dunno...
pur <u>p</u> le			
tub <u>a</u>		<u>t</u> ubam <u>a</u> b <u>a</u>	
w <u>o</u> nder	<u>w</u> ondam <u>a</u> der	<u>w</u> onderm <u>a</u> der	<u>w</u> onnnm <u>a</u> der?
w <u>o</u> nderful	<u>w</u> onderm <u>a</u> fu <u>l</u>	<u>w</u> onderm <u>a</u> fu <u>l</u>	<u>w</u> onderm <u>a</u> fu <u>l</u>

Q.5.1 We’ve left out some of their responses. In the table on the answer sheet, fill in the blanks with the appropriate words from the list below.

<u>p</u> urpam <u>a</u> pl <u>e</u>	<u>o</u> ctemat <u>e</u> t	<u>t</u> ubam <u>a</u> b <u>a</u>	<u>t</u> uuum <u>a</u> b <u>a</u>
<u>p</u> urplem <u>a</u> pl <u>e</u>	<u>o</u> camat <u>e</u> t	<u>p</u> urrrm <u>a</u> pl <u>e</u>	

Q.5.2 How would each respondent say the words listed? We’ve given you a few to get started.

Q.5.3 What motivates Alan’s, Barbara’s, and Chris’s eventual answers and uncertainties?